moment in this electoral segment. In a post-Ram mandir era, which is being projected as a great assertion of Hindu identity, the Muslims are increasingly feeling cornered because of multiple issues, including the National Register of Citizens (NRC) exercise in Assam and the implementation of the Citizenship Amendment Act, 2019 (CAA). The CAA, whose rules were notified just before the polling dates, enables refugees from all other religions except Islam to gain citizenship to the country with easier norms. The incidents of lynching on suspicion of cow smuggling, shutting down of madrassas and use of bulldozers by the state machinery as an extra-judicial punitive measure, mostly against Muslims, have exacerbated the community's feeling of being discriminated against. "There is a quiet disquiet among the Muslim voters," says Navaid Hamid, former president of the All India Muslim Majlis-e-Mushawarat and former member of the National Integration Council. "The sense of alienation has reached a new height."

This could partly unify the Muslim vote. "Reports have also shown that Muslims are trying to vote strategically, motivated by a general existential threat," says Aligarh's Fahad Zuberi, who is now a scholar at Oxford University. The pattern has already been evident in almost all state polls after the 2019 Lok Sabha election, where the Muslims have largely voted against the BJP and in favour of its leading rival party. CSDS surveys show that 77 per cent of the Muslims voted for the *mahagathbandhan* (a grand alliance of parties opposed to the BJP) in the 2020 Bihar election, 75 per cent Muslims voted for the Trinamool Congress (TMC) in the 2021 Bengal election, and 79 per cent of the community voted for the SP in the 2022 UP election. That the Muslims have begun to consolidate behind a single party that could potentially defeat the BJP was evident in these polls. The SP's vote share among the Muslims in UP saw a massive uptick of 33 percentage points, the TMC's in West Bengal by 24 percentage points. "The community is feeling besieged, and keeping the BJP out of power is a serious political goal for them," says Irfan Engineer, secretary at the Centre for Study of Society and Secularism in Mumbai. "They are likely to vote unitedly with the intention of defeating the BJP." Professor Moonesa Bushra Abdi, executive member of the All-India Muslim Personal Law Board, agrees: "The BJP's anti-Muslim agenda itself is the binding factor."

The Opposition Strategy

The Opposition camp this election is focused on consolidating the Muslim votes around alliances or on key issues concerning them. In UP, for instance, the Congress and the SP, two parties that have a significant support base among the Muslims, have come together. While Rahul Gandhi's '*Mohabbat ki dukan*' narrative is projected as an antidote to the BJP's alleged communal agenda against Muslims, the SP has been following the PDA or Pichhada, Dalit and Alpasankhyak formula, which had pushed its tally from 47 MLAs in the 2017 assembly polls to 111 in 2022. In Bengal, the ruling TMC has not shied away from directly wooing the Muslim voters. Immediately after the notification of the CAA rules in March, West Bengal chief minister and TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee lost no time in connecting CAA implementation with the NRC claiming that this was a ploy to send the Muslims to detention centres. The party's manifesto promises that if it comes to power at the Centre, it will scrap CAA and NRC and stop the implementation of the Uniform Civil Code, three provisions that have been a constant source of worry for the Muslims. This is said to have consolidated the entire Muslim vote behind the TMC. In Kerala, both the ruling CPI(M)-led Left Democratic Front and the Opposition Congress-led United Democratic Front have used the anti-BJP card to woo the 26 per cent Muslims in their midst. The Opposition parties are also confident of sweeping the three Muslim-majority seats in Kashmir, now reduced to a UT.

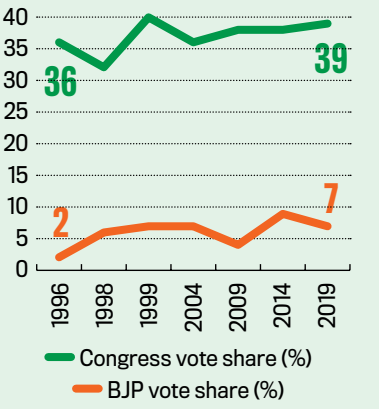
MANY POLITICAL LEADERS CONCEDE THAT FIELDING MUSLIM CANDIDATES IS COUNTER-PRODUCTIVE, AS IT CONSOLIDATES THE HINDU VOTE AGAINST THEM

In Bihar, the *mahagathbandhan* of the RJD, Congress and Left parties is also banking on the consolidation of the Muslim votes, which have traditionally remained split among the RJD, Congress and JD(U). Lalu's demand for reservations for Muslims was no slip of the tongue. The party has been seeking to build a formidable core M-Y or

WHICH WAY

CONGRESS vs BJP

How the Muslims have voted for the two national parties



POOR STRIKE RATE

Less than five per cent of the Muslim candidates manage to win Lok Sabha polls

